Darebin siblings in conversation

Interviewer: Thank you all for joining me and supporting this research. A lot of research about Jewish identity and connectedness and journeys asks parents about their kids or asks individuals about themselves. So I thought I'd do it a bit differently and invite the people who were raised in the same house and ask them about how they are – Jewishly – now and what got them to where they are now. That's the rough overview. Let's start where you are now, what you're up to, how old you are now, and then we might take a walk down memory lane. Who wants to start?

Mason: Let's start with the youngest. Ashton, you got to go.

Interviewer: Please, Ashton.

Ashton: The least amount of time has elapsed since I was at school. [Pauses] So, yes, Ashton. I'm twenty-eight now and went to -

Mason: Yeah, I know. Twenty-eight!

Ashton: Yeah. It's a bit of a shock, isn't it?

Ashton: Nowadays I'm the director of [Jewish humanist community], which is a Humanistic Jewish community in Melbourne, which I co-founded along with these two guys in 2012. So, have been volunteering since then and now into an employed position, running the organisation. That takes up my activity time and the remainder of the time is just living through COVID. Is there any other pieces of information that you're interested in?

Interviewer: So you've already finished studying?

Ashton: I've finished studying, yeah.

Interviewer: What did you study?

Ashton: I studied Arts/Science at Monash - was my undergrad. And then went on to do a Master of Urban Horticulture at Melbourne, so the environmental space, mostly through the six and a half years of studying. And that's definitely something I'm very passionate about - environmentalism, sustainability and then also have this other narrative of Judaism education being another twin passion. So, so far it's been a mixture of both more education in Judaism in terms of the employment and volunteering side.

Interviewer: Tell me a bit about [Jewish humanist community].

Ashton: [Jewish humanist community] is a **Humanistic** - we say it's another word for **agnostic secular stream** of Judaism that was formally established in America about fifty or sixty years ago. In Australia there hasn't really been a Humanistic formal Jewish community organised until we started it. I co-founded it with Archer and a few others as well in 2012 when I got back from Shnat with Habonim Dror, which is a leftist Socialist-Zionist youth movement where, at the time, there was a lot of discussion about **cultural Judaism**, which is another word for **secular Judaism**. And a lot of that was inspired by Mason, because Mason was a madrich at the time who was running seminars for chanichim on Jewish culture and Jewish secularism. And when I was in Shnat, he also ran a course on cultural Judaism for our Shnatties, so that was what inspired the beginning of that

movement. And since then it just evolved and turned to a bigger community than we'd ever originally intended it to be, and ran with it. So originally it was just a meeting for Shabbat, Kabbalat Shabbat, once a week and then we started doing Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur and then started doing more chagim and smachot, and now it's a little fully fledged community, I'd say.

Interviewer: Isn't it wonderful when things get so out of hand that they outgrow our wildest expectations? Wow.

Ashton: Yeah. It definitely has. And now we're just trying to catch up with it rather than the other way around.

Interviewer: How wonderful. It's incredible. Mason? I'll jump to the other end, sorry. Leave the middles for the middle!

Mason: Middles for middle. I'm thirty-two years of age at the moment. A couple of years have definitely passed between cups of tea! It's pretty crazy, actually. Yeah, thirty-two - far out! What have I done in the last -? I went on Shnat which is, I think, a big part of my identity, which I always try to put there, a bigger part of Habonim Dror. Also, if we're going to lead into Jewish identity eventually, I think [Traditional Jewish school], graduating there was a huge part of that. But since then, came back, went to university, studied theology and religion, believe it or not, did an Arts degree - theology and religion were my majors. And then I moved to Israel - lived there for seven years overseas, lived in Israel for six or seven years and then found my partner, my significant other, who's still with me now. I dragged her back to Australia. She's less happy about that than I am. She's currently living with me here in Australia. And once I moved to Israel I actually became a farmer. I've been farming for the last decade so I've been living on the Morning Peninsula for the last four years and I've recently just finished up my farming stint there and I'm in between - moving on to finding other farming projects.

Interviewer: What sort of farming?

Mason: Organic vegetable farming.

Interviewer: So in Israel you were a farmer. Who did you marry?

Mason: We haven't actually married.

Interviewer: Or coupled with, I should say. That was very old fashioned, sorry. I'll take that back. With whom do you share a roof?

Mason: [Laughs] There's been a role thing. I'm quite into getting married. She's actually more, "Whatever." For her it doesn't really mean much. Her name is […]. She's from the north of Israel and we met over there, I think after I'd been living there for two and a half years. She's also a farmer. So we met up and then together we've been on a farming journey and we built a small business together. It's a very special relationship.

Interviewer: Sounds very cool. I'm intrigued by the religion at university. I'm interested in now, Jewishly. How do you interact with it, what does it mean for you, what kind of words come to mind if someone asked you to describe yourself?

Mason: I'm interested to hear what the brothers will say after about that.

Commented [User1]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels created by the participants to define their self-concept.

Ashton defines their movement as an **"agnostic secular stream"** and **"cultural Judaism"**, terms used to capture a substantive identity content that avoids traditional religious labels.

Since living in Israel for that chunk of time and having an Israeli partner, she's **Israelified** my Jewish identity. And I think that's been a large part because I've had to make her expression of Judaism inside our relationship - her moving to Australia more palatable for her. Her identity in Israel was very much a secular Jewish identity. She loved the chagim. For her, her identity was a nationalistic identity, essentially, you know, she spoke Hebrew, she didn't have to think about identity. I had quite a strong, I think, very practising, culturally Jewish identity. I loved speaking the language, loved the chagim, but I practised the chagim in a more traditional Jewish background that came from the parents and from a [Traditional Jewish school] background, which I adored, but then shifting that into a very culturally secular Jewish identity which is something that I became very identified with later on. But since, I think the last, say, five-six years, have become much more - we speak Hebrew in the household. I feel very Jewish, speaking the language. And for her, for example, Friday night is just cooking a massive Israeli - it's all dishes that she's familiar with. We say the brachot, light the candles, say the brachot over the challot. And that's kind of become my Jewish identity much more where, before meeting her, I would be participating in [the Jewish humanist community] on a Friday night, I'd be much more active over the chagim, and those elements have kind of faded away at the moment.

Interviewer: I'm supposing that there's an individual private identity that doesn't necessarily get interrupted but has to accommodate another identity?

Mason: For sure.

Interviewer: We're building a common identity at home.

Mason: Spot on. I think building our household and "What does it mean?" And I think also, which we can talk about, I think, the Australian Jewish identity stands in contrast hugely to an Israeli identity. So I think she's been also very sometimes shocked by the identity that I brought with me when we met, my Jewish identity. So I've had to understand and negotiate that identity to build one which supports her in feeling Jewish, because she doesn't identify with my Australian Jewish identity very much. So I've had to become a little more her and she a little me. So it's been a negotiation, for sure.

Interviewer: Meet somewhere in the middle.

Mason: For sure.

Interviewer: Actually, Ran Porat wrote a dissertation about five years ago on the 'Ausraelis'. You can actually probably get it off Figshare - it's the Monash portal for doctoral research. He did a really interesting job of trying to capture what it means to be Israeli and Australian. It might be interesting for her to have a look at.

Mason: For sure. What's it called - Ausraeli?

Interviewer: Ausraelis - A-U-S- and then raelis. If you can't find it just get in touch - I'll send it your way.

Mason: Hundred percent.

Interviewer: Yeah, very interesting. In fact Ran Porat is actually presenting on his findings from his dissertation next week. Timely.

Mason: I will. If I can't find it I'll definitely send you an email. I'd love to read that.

Commented [User2]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses sibling dialogue to distinguish between "identity optimization" (refining stable commitments) and fundamental developmental crises.

Mason describes how his identity has been **"Israelified"** by his partner. Rather than a crisis of faith, this represents **identity optimization**—a "secondary crisis" where he shifts his "practising, culturally Jewish identity" into a "culturally secular" one to accommodate his domestic life.

Interviewer: All right. It provides a language which I think you say "Is relevant," or you say, "No, it's not." But at least it's a vocabulary to describe something that sometimes remains in the unvoiced sense.

Mason: I appreciate that.

Interviewer: Archer?

Archer: Hi, [interviewer]. So nice to see you.

Interviewer: Good to see you.

Archer: And thanks - it's the privilege of being able to talk about stuff for an hour and listen to my brothers. So thank you. It's lovely to listen to them from an external perspective, because we have these chats all the time in different ways, so it's just interesting when you're put to the microphone.

I'm thirty-four. I now have a child and another one on the way, so these guys are uncles, which is fun. My son's twenty-two months. His name is […] and we have another one coming December 27th. We don't know the gender but it's fun times. Can't wait.

My journey, in many ways, is so similar to these guys. [Traditional Jewish school] and Habo, which has played such a formative role in my life. I attribute probably just about everything I do to, I think, Habo, in many ways. Came back from Shnat and really fell in love with the movement here and hadracha and the world of Jewish informal education which is such a phenomenal little innovative world that I was struck by I don't think I realised at the time. Just loved working with young people and exploring, I thought, meaningful and relevant questions around identity. So just kept doing that. I studied at university - I studied Arts/Science - super broad. Like these guys, also very strong environmental stream through all three of us, so studied conservation biology and ecology in the science realm and then Jewish history at Monash on the Arts side of things. And then, somehow, ended up running the informal Jewish education department, pretty much starting that at [Pluralistic Jewish school].

I think, on the basis of a reputation of giving at least six years of everything I had to informal education and March of the Living and the myriad of opportunities that come out of the Jewish community and landed that with my best friend, […] and we've kind of used that as a lab for four years, having a lot of fun and not having any real idea what we were doing, but building something that we were pretty proud of and I think was pretty impressive at the time. So that was wonderful. And at some point in that action we founded, on the back of **Hertzl-Mason** here, [Jewish humanist community], which started in my living room in East St Kilda and, as Ashton said, we had a hunch around there was a thirst or a need or a want underlying a lot of Jewish people in the community. And the hunch was correct because it's grown and it's thriving and it's going to continue to grow and thrive, it seems. So that's really interesting and beautiful. I still chair the board there, so there involved but at a high level. Ashton is the real brains and heart behind it all.

And post-[Pluralistic Jewish school] it was kind of just professionalising myself as an educator and becoming a full-time madrich, really, which is where I've been the last number of years, but kind of taking that to many different places which I use as a kind of education designer and in higher ed and for corporate and non-profit and all that sort of stuff, mostly around leadership potential, team culture, motivation, all that sort of stuff. Just about anything, really. So I got facilitator and experience designer, essentially. So that's kind of been my journey. And I've just made the commitment to take all my work

Commented [User3]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels created by the participants to define their self-concept.

Archer refers to his brother as **"Hertzl-Mason"**, a participant-generated metaphor that links Mason's identity to Zionism and the founding of their community.

in the environmental space as well – it's a global imperative I can't ignore anymore. So, like these guys, it's been this fascinating dance between the two worlds of, I guess in many ways, Jewish education and wider education in our environment. That's a little snapshot there.

Interviewer: As much as they're separate passions, they're related, it seems. They seem to inform one another. It's not like you're having a break from one there. They seem to work together.

Archer: Definitely.

Interviewer**:** In a perfect methodology, I would have interviewed you at three, popped back in your lives in high school and then interview you now – about now. That's ideal because you have a chance to ask a person in real-time what's happening in their lives. Reflection can be a rough stick. But sometimes hindsight also has something powerful to offer. Sometimes we shape it all into a narrative that is quite clarifying. I'm curious - what led to here? I meet so many Australian Jewish young people who tell me they're very, very different to their siblings; they've gone in very different directions, they might have had the same beginning but they're different now. And yet, three strapping young men who are very comfortable in the educational, Jewish environment, [Jewish humanist community] space. Where did it come from? What were the critical experiences that got you to where you're currently sitting?

Mason: You're the eldest, Archer. You have to say a few things.

Archer: **The first thing that jumps out is just how incredibly similar the three of us are. I think, until like, I don't know, maybe my mid-twenties, I used to think all siblings were identical and had the same belief systems and values and were best friends. And then realised that we're a complete anomaly, the three of us, in many ways**. And I've spoken about it with Mason, actually, at length, like "How did this happen? How did we kind of all spin out so similarly?" There's no exact answer to that. I'm not sure. Certainly, the things that pop out – I'll talk about rather than my own story for now. We've **a very strong mother** who I think played a huge role - very strong values and such a deep attention to all three of us on our own individual journeys and upbringings, and that must of played a huge role and cultivated a real closeness. Her role in the world has been us, as a project, so I think there's something in that.

Certainly for Mason and I, any thought journey that I was or experience I was in, I'd drag him straight into it, and so we were constantly at this fascinating interplay of debating and exploring all ideas together. And then Ashton was always kind of there just listening all along. But Mason and I, we just always, just constantly bouncing ideas and ideologies and how we want to show up and live in the world, and it was like that since we were fourteen, I reckon - twelve, just about. So maybe that's had such a huge impact on us.

And then, **I'll speak collectively - you guys can jump in** - but obviously [Traditional Jewish school] Doncaster had a huge role - We all grew up in Doncaster. Jewish day school, I think, had quite an impact as a primary school, but I think the Doncaster Jewish community is a really interesting one and also had a big impact in some ways. And then, "Bang!" - [Traditional Jewish school]. I think March of the Living was a huge one for me - massive, massive, massive. Shnat, Habo, [Jewish humanist community], they're the big -

Mason: I think as well – obviously, there's the brotherly level, which a hundred percent spot on. And mum. I think they're the two. Ashton, would you agree as well? Is that something, in terms of mum's role, is one that all of us will agree on?

Archer: I'm going to add dad, too, but in a totally different way -

Mason: Completely different way.

Archer: - maybe not being Jewish, because our father's not Jewish, and never converted, which is a whole PhD in itself, I think.

Mason: But looked Jewish.

Interviewer: But looked Jewish? More Jewish than you guys?

Mason: Yeah. Dad had a big beard. I remember he used to come to shule with us and he'd walk in and people would just take him as being the Jewish guy. And he was like, "No idea." But he looked the part. He put a kippah on his head, he had the big beard, he put a suit on and he'd look the part completely.

Ashton: His name is […].

Interviewer: Doesn't strike you as a particularly Jewish name, no.

Ashton: No. Well, Jesus was Jewish, so maybe. But the funniest part is I remember for their bar mitzvahs, when they were called on to the bima, it was like, "Archer and Mason ben who?" And it was like, "What is Dad's Hebrew name going to be? Is it […] ben Abraham?" First Jew, first Christian, is that right?

Mason: He was, but that also leads back to what Archer was saying about identity and the strength in point as well, because I remember, in the early stages, it was kind of like, "All right. There's dad. What do we call him? Do you stand up in shule and you say, 'ben […]?" You can say that but it was like, at least being in quite an Orthodox shule in Doncaster, a Chabad shul, was kind of like, "Do you even can say the name, '[…]' or '[…]' in the shul?" And there was. It was like, "Do we call him ben Abraham? Do we say 'ben […]?" And we spoke about this. And I think there was once or twice where he got called 'ben Abraham' or something until one of us was kind of like, "Hold on. This is dad. Let's just call him - we're the son of […]. That's who we are. It does not bear on our Jewish identity that our dad isn't Jewish. In fact, dad was one of the biggest supporters of us being Jewish and practising our Jewish identity.

Interviewer: In what sense?

Mason: We've had a very interesting upbringing with dad in the sense that he's both grappled with very much being an outsider, being not Jewish in a Jewish family. We hold our identity very strong, so we've had a lot of heavy conversations, debates around the table around Jewish identity which has been heated of dad saying, "Screw religion. It's this. It's that." And then him being like, "Oh my God. How was I not brought up in this Jewish community? My upbringing was conservatively kind of like - it didn't have the flavours of culture, of language, of dialog, of family dinners." He never had that. So when he saw how beautiful it was in our life, he was just like, "Guys. I'm going to be there for you. I'm going to make sure that this is a part of your identity because it's something I never had and I can see the value in it."

Commented [User4]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme captures "interactional action units" where siblings corroborate, challenge, or refine shared history, preventing the distortion of "family myths" often found in individual reports.

Archer initiates a narrative about their upbringing, stating, "The first thing that jumps out is just how incredibly similar the three of us are... we're a complete anomaly". Mason immediately provides **relational verification**, adding, "I think as well... Mum. I think they're the two," and then prompts Ashton to confirm: "Ashton, would you agree?"

Commented [User5]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme captures "interactional action units" where siblings corroborate, challenge, or refine shared history, preventing the distortion of "family myths" often found in individual reports.

The siblings engage in **narrative repair** regarding their father's identity. While acknowledging he is not Jewish, they negotiate the memory of his presence in the synagogue. Ashton provides a humorous correction regarding their father's name ("His name is […]"), leading Mason to clarify the specific communal negotiation of their father being called "ben Abraham" versus "ben […]" on the *bima* [76–77]. This interaction disrupts a simplified "Jewish-only" narrative by revealing the complexities of their inter-faith household.

N.B. The father's name was anonymised to protect the respondents' identities. For context, it is a very typical Christian-sounding name.

Archer: Yeah. It's interesting. We talk about this in [Jewish humanist community]. Taking theism out of Judaism, which we think is one part of Judaism, is God, it's very central. But you don't throw baby out with the bath water. We come from one of the most richest structures - I think it's the most rich community structure that any culture's ever had. It's so beautiful. And maybe part of our thinking around that and wanting to honour and keep that structure in our lives, the flow of the year and the calendar and chagim is, dad always used to say, like maybe he just illuminated that to us as an outsider, so early on. I don't know guys - I'm just thinking about that off the top of my head. Like he would always say, "Such a brilliant structure or such a brilliant - ." You know, maybe there's something. He made us realise that so early. I don't know. And then mum just always so proud of being Jewish and the Holocaust stuff. But I definitely wouldn't say any of us have a negative Jewish identity. It's such a positive, strong - Judaism is enriching, it's not just because -

Mason: For sure.

Interviewer: Can I take you back to a few points, Archer? You said March of the Living was an important stage or experience. Why?

Archer: Yeah. Such an interesting one. I'd like to hear these guys.

Interviewer: Did you all go?

Mason: Yeah, we all did.

Interviewer: What did that do as an experience that was part of that journey?

Mason: Archer, you'll have to lead this one because you went on it first and **there was a ripple effect** after you came back.

Archer: It was the first time overseas. We travelled extensively in Australia as a family, beginning with my first rite of passage bar-mitzvah is we drove from Darwin to Broome for six weeks in a campervan. I remember **mum taking us out of school** and the school, [Traditional Jewish school], was very angry that I was going to miss five weeks of school. She's like, "What are you talking about? **This is education**. Let's go and drive across Australia and see the Aboriginal communities as a family and learn together. That's education." Which maybe has informed, again, so much of my beliefs around education. What a rite of passage!

And I think March of the Living was the next one, but it was the first time overseas. So in my eyes, it was wild. I mean, Poland - because on our mum's side, which really feels like our strongest connection, our grandparents are both survivors. Very close to my bubba, who I still see as the greatest role model and matriarch of our family on my mum's side, who we're so close with and so much Yiddishkeit. March of the Living was huge. It sparked my fascination with genocide and the darkest part of humanity which, funnily enough, I saw so much light in that. It was the light in the dark that I was always drawn to, which is why I continue to study a lot of - I lived in Rwanda for five months and I led March of the Living four times. And there's something about that which is fascinating and my lineage there.

And then it was the first time in Israel, which was mind blowing - like absolutely mind blowing going to Israel for a week. I remember my madrich, I think […] or […] was my madrich - you probably know. He was at [Traditional Jewish school] - or no, Tom? Anyway, basically my mouth was open for a week. I walked around like this [demonstrates, mouth open]. I just couldn't believe the nationalism, Judaism blew my

mind. I came back wearing a kippah, I think. Is that right, Mason? I wore a kippah for a year?

Mason: Yeah.

Archer: I remember skateboarding in the city with Mason. There was like little blonde skateboarders and I'd wear a kippah wherever I went.

Mason: And sandals. You brought the revolution of sandals back from Israel. We were like, "What are these things, Sandals? We're in Melbourne, damn it!"

Archer: Maybe that's kind of a start, yeah. I don't know. You guys?

Mason: Skip to Ashton. Ashton? I want to hear the perspective from somebody from the other side of the corridor.

Ashton: On March of the Living, particularly?

Mason: Yeah.

Ashton: Hey?

Mason: Yeah.

Ashton: It didn't have the same, I think looking back, the same impact on my Jewish identity that it did to Archer and Mason. I guess we'll see on that. But I remember both of you did go through more of a religious phase, it seemed, after March of the Living, and both of you we wearing kippot. I didn't ever go through that. I think that was **the one thing I didn't mirror in our upbringing** is that little transition and indifferent to **some more religious exploration of Judaism**. So I'm not sure. Maybe I wasn't mature enough at the time to grasp a lot of the deeper meanings behind it, and I found more of an impact when I went to Poland on Shnat because Habonim offered a program as well for a week in the middle of summer going to Poland. And by that time, maybe I was more mature or educational methodologies used in that time were just a lot more resonant with me. But again, I viewed it more from an ethical perspective and really was fascinated about the moral discussions of Nazism and survivors and meaning. So it didn't reinvigorate my Jewish identity in any particular way.

I was probably more sparked by Zionism. I think that was more of the exciting part for me and I was reading a book on Shnat which Mason told me about, the Anthology of Secular Humanistic Judaism, and that anthology went through writings from Jewish authors, back to Spinoza and all the way up to the twentieth century. That was a lot more about nationalism and peoplehood and autonomy and culture, and I probably fell in love with the romantic idea of the wholesome Jewish culture in Israel and really going back to that. The beautiful stories of ancient Israel and the immersive culture of the Jewish people, that was what really inspired me, and living in Israel. The chagim on Shnat were just the most beautiful part for me. I think they were the highlights of my year there, that, as an eighteen-year-old with all my friends, you'd expect that the best memories would be some of the wild times that we had. But in fact it was the chagim that dotted that year with so meaningful, so different from growing up in Australia, especially Doncaster, which is slightly removed from the Jewish experience in Melbourne. But to be in Israel it was just like, "Wow, this is insane." And that's when I think I fell more in love with my Jewish identity, was seeing how they played out when everyone around me was Jewish and what potential is there to live in an immersive culture. So maybe a little bit later on.

Mason: We actually all went on March of the Living and then all went [to Poland] on Shnat?

Archer: No, my program didn't take us on Shnat.

Interviewer: That was only a later invention. I don't think it was at that time. Mason, I'm curious. Complete the picture.

Mason: Complete the picture? I think **I'm a sandwich of the two** in that sense. I think Archer coming back from going on March of the Living was a massive influence on my identity, and I think that came probably more from what he brought back from his experience of being in Israel. He came back and was invigorated, I think, in his Zionist identity and also the land of milk and honey. He came back with this energy of like, "Holy Moly! You should have seen what I saw there. This is something special." Like Ashton was saying, Archer and I have, just because I think we're a lot closer in our age, **we had an interesting dynamic where we would just always feed off each other**. So when he came back **it was as if I'd been on the experience.** He'd come back and we'd just be - that's it. We'd be talking and debating and this and that. So it was almost like I'd been on the experience.

I remember I came back and I delved quite deeply, I think, into my more theistic and religious identity within Judaism which was very nourishing for me. I really enjoyed it. It was a beautiful experience. I remember also I think I was wearing kippah for a while, I would attend the shule at [Traditional Jewish school] a lot more, I think I really got involved. I had a couple of cracking teachers at school during that period who helped, I think, really inspire and feed that part of me that came back when Archer, and then obviously when I took off and did that two years later. I think that, again, it just reinvigorated that part of my identity which, at that stage as I said, was much more on the religious - like I was very fascinated and very in tune, I think, with that part of - I was very much believing in a God, very much believing in a - I don't even know how to phrase it.

The Orthodoxy of Judaism was something which was very nourishing for me. I loved the stories, I loved the energy, I loved the feel of being in a shule with other people singing songs that had meaning. And I think there was a theistic spiritual connection as well - I'll say it that way. Now I have a lot of spiritual notions. I'm a very spiritual person but I'm tuned in with a different element of spirituality. Then it was very theistic. Now it's a different energy of spirituality. But I think, without a doubt, March of the Living was a massive influence in that. I think, the Zionist aside, it was a more nourishing part.

Interviewer: It's interesting. People go to Israel and sometimes see part of the smorgasbord that doesn't exist here. To see many people living in an authentic way allows you to imagine that such a thing you could actually do. Although what I'm fascinated about is you all seem to have spoken, I think, positively about [Traditional Jewish school] and yet [Traditional Jewish school] was not a Humanistic school. So what role did school play, if at all, in where you are now? Was it a conduit to something else? What was [Traditional Jewish school]? What was that education because, you know, you had Jewish studies teachers - not all of them were Orthodox. It's quite a diverse teacher body. But what was positive about a [Traditional Jewish school] Jewish education?

Mason: Good question. I think what's also fascinating about that is there was this almost dualistic experience going on. We were all throughout high school incredibly involved in Habonim which was, again, a incredibly Israeli spin on your identity. It was about language, culture, folk dancing, the stories and also it was -

Commented [User6]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme identifies the mesosystemic laboratory by showing how macro-level factors (school, youth movements) are filtered through micro-level family dynamics.

Mason describes the **"ripple effect"** of Archer's experiences. When Archer returned from Israel, Mason felt "as if I'd been on the experience" because they would "always feed off each other". This illustrates how a macro-systemic experience (a trip to Israel) is transmitted to a sibling through the family microsystem.

Archer connects his mother's **micro-level** parenting decisions (taking them out of school to travel Australia) to his **macro-level** beliefs about education as a "rite of passage," illustrating the intersection of nested developmental systems.

Commented [User7]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses sibling dialogue to distinguish between "identity optimization" (refining stable commitments) and fundamental developmental crises.

Ashton uses his brothers' history as a foil to define his own, noting that he did not "mirror" the "religious exploration" Archer and Mason experienced after their *March of the Living* trip.

Archer: Identity, identity, identity.

Mason: Yeah, identity, identity, identity. But also when it came to identity as well, which is something we kind of rebelled against later on in our Habo identity, it was very empty when it came to tradition, Chagim and that element of Jewish identity. So it kind of filled the part of our being the civilisational part of Judaism that we were really into the connection, the cultural side, but the other side it didn't. I think [Traditional Jewish school] had an incredible role in nourishing that part. I think I had a really big hunger. I think, from primary school again, it was a Chabad school. When I think back at the teachers, I think of the Rabbi's wife was our Jewish studies teacher and I remember so fondly every Friday we'd run through the parasha and we'd read - I've still got the Chumash that we used to read as kids. It's still on my bookshelf [Archer and Mason gesture to their bookshelves behind them]. I had no idea what I was reading but there was something so familiar.

Archer: Mine is there.

Mason: And I think there was that familiarity that translated across at [Traditional Jewish school] and it was fed in a more intellectual way and it was a develop of that. But it felt very at home, I think, at least for me. I felt like I could access and I could find people who could answer questions and who could challenge my identity. And I think I got challenged from all those things as well, really, there. It was stimulating, I think, my [Traditional Jewish school] Jewish identity. Very stimulating.

Interview: Late in January 1901, Eliezer Ben-Yehuda invented the word 'identity'. It was in his newspaper, HaZvi. You can find it online, actually. Tel Aviv has an archive. And he said, "There is mi-hut but there isn't ze-hut. Freud had spoken about identity, but had not yet published extensively – it was only in his private letters. He hadn't actually formalised the idea. So it turns out that an off-the-derech Chabadnick who decided that religion wasn't for him but the Hebrew language would become his Judaism, but also steeped in classical texts that was at a profound level, which he then took to a cultural and, I guess, a language level. It's really interesting that the word that he chose for identity is 'thisness' which is both precise and also extremely vague. I can point at it, because when I see it I recognise it. It's that. But not necessarily that ability to put it into words.

Mason: In words.

Interviewer: Which is really interesting. Mason, you spoke a little bit about […] and sort of coming to a shared identity. Archer, I don't know anything about your partner. Has there been a, Jewish-growing-together or were you already sort of in a similar space?

Archer: My wife is […], who you might also know? Maybe not? You do? From [Traditional Jewish school]? Year below me.

Interviewer: Yes.

Archer: […]'s background is [Modern Orthodox synagogue and school], the […] family. But that had a very negative influence, I think. Her perception of Judaism when we met was very much – it had an energy of restrictiveness. It was rules, there were laws, she had to do things for the sake of it. Her dad is the only sibling of the […] family, the rest are Orthodox and even Hareidi in Israel, one part of the family - he's the only one that kind of didn't, but it was all this like hiding from grandparents. So she had a very kind of negative image. She meets me and I'm like the literal polar opposite, like Judaism is the empowering structure, and the structures and rules are just beautiful, empowering structures and rules that give us life and enrich us rather than take riches away from us.

Interviewer: And you didn't both run away from each other when you met! This is interesting.

Archer: [Laughs] We definitely didn't, which is good. I'm the primary parent in many ways. […]'s a doctor - she's going to be an obstetrician, so her career is more linear and takes precedence. She earns much more money than I do and so I'm kind of like the home. The home is almost my domain and it's good because she believes in everything, she's a huge fan of [Jewish humanist community] and what we've created and loves Judaism as there and sees its value, but she doesn't drive it in the home in the way that I do.

The [Traditional Jewish school] thing is such a coloured question. I don't have answers for it. I really didn't like school in general. I had a issue with school, and which I questioned, so maybe I attribute some of that negativity to [Traditional Jewish school]. I just remembered, from age sixteen up, being like, "This is a waste of time. Half this is just meaningless and irrelevant stuff that plays no role in my life or existence and the rest of my journey. What a f*cking waste of my life." And I still hold that frustration and anger inside me and maybe, again, often I'm on journeys to heal our wounds. Maybe part of my passion for education is that it is a waste of time and it is letting people down and it isn't letting people thrive in the current academic education VCE system. So it's hard to know what [Traditional Jewish school] did. I don't know whether the combination of home and Habo was the greatest driver. I don't know how to put [Traditional Jewish school] in there. If it had a huge role, I just don't realise it subconsciously but certainly in terms of very conscious drivers of Jewish identity. I don't know. I lived in the music department. These guys were more high school - they were captain captains, I was music captain. I disappeared and didn't get involved with the informal crew. I remember really enjoying the Jewish education part, definitely, and chagim, but I don't know. It's interesting.

Interviewer: My aim for this research project is to get the voices of Melbourne, so I had a Hasidic family on Monday night - very interesting. Last night a group that called themselves, 'Die Hard Bnei Akiva and, in fact, several of the siblings were actually sitting there in the interview with their Bnei Akiva jumpers – in their late twenties. And I had a family that refused to call themselves anything other than 'alternative' and their story proved that. That was certainly the case! I'm not really sure what to do with them but really, really interesting. I've never met a family of siblings that were more diverse in every way. They didn't even look related. But one of them made a really interesting comment, Archer. She said, "I hated school. I wasn't academic. I never fit in. But I have one friend and that one friend dragged me to a youth movement, and at that youth movement I met someone else." And so it was almost a ripple effect, if you want to use that metaphor, or that in the broader scheme of things it was extremely important because of what it enables, not necessarily what it was. Does that make sense?

Archer: Yep, definitely. It definitely plays a central, pivotal role in all the stuff that I'm involved in. Maybe you're right - just my mere fact that I was there and the links to the networks and the connections that it gave, more than the experience and journey itself. I don't know.

Interviewer: Maybe come back to you with that question in about ten/fifteen years -

Archer: Yeah.

Interviewer: - see. See what the passage of time has done. Jewish friends? Anyone still friends with friends from school or is it different? Is it all [Jewish humanist community]? Is it diverse? How important are school friends or Jewish friends to where you are now?

Archer: Ashton, you take this one.

Ashton: I guess, because of the school, you guys have maybe retained some personal friends but by your late twenties you probably *have* your friends, in many ways. That post-high school group is from Habo. Actually, most of my friends, probably all of them, are Jewish, so that's definitely been the factor of my relationships and friendships of people that are Jewish, with the exception of work mates along the way. But my closest friends are still from Habo and we've retained those links from ten years ago and in many ways they're as strong, if not stronger, than they were ten years ago. And some of them went to [Traditional Jewish school], so that's just a coincidence but it's more Habo. But I think **it's much the same with Mason and Archer as well**.

Interviewer: And Mason, would you want to add, disagree?

Mason: Yeah, **mixed**. I've kept the majority of my Jewish friends and I think, in terms of strength and identity, they were some of my biggest partners in reinforcing my identity. Certainly in Habo. It was one of my biggest influences in strengthening my identity and I could always bounce off people ideas. When we started practising some of our more alternative expressions of our Jewish identity, it was always - I had a number of partners, one of them, the earliest was […], who, we sat together and he was also a fascinating character of not connecting at all to his Jewish identity, but very passionate suddenly about coming together and talking and then using the chagim as this framework to fall back on. And having that friendship enabled me to have a common language and to explore, which was very beautiful.

And since coming back to Australia, my friendship has actually radically changed. I have a lot of my Jewish friends that I'm in contact with but living rurally, and Jews don't match, so that changed. So most of my friendship group now is almost a hundred percent not Jewish, but it's actually been interesting how it's almost an impossibility for me to express my identity without a Jewish side. I have one of my close friends now, she sends me photos of challot that she makes every week, because she lived with us and we had Pesach on the farm every year which became this big event. And half the people there were always non-Jewish people who now, when it's coming up to Passover, they're like, "When's Passover dinner happening?" They know about it.

So those people of like community and Jewish identity has always been such a number one thing in my life that it's been a very beautiful thing witnessing how [pause] I've dropped off because I haven't had [Jewish humanist community] and that, those people around me. That element of identity has fallen away because I didn't have the community to support me, but there were elements that I could still relive that identity, I just had to find partners who were like-minded. And I think that's been something that's, I think, our secular Jewish identity has been really helpful in making sure that it helped me remain Jewish and practising because I had a language that translated across to people who weren't even of a Jewish background but they could understand it. It was this **vernacular** that suddenly they could speak as well and I could identify with. So that's been an interesting one the last few years, for sure.

Commented [User8]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels created by the participants to define their self-concept.

Mason describes their identity as a **"vernacular"**—a language of secular Jewishness that allows him to translate his values to non-Jewish friends.

Interviewer: And I guess, just like you said before, that your dad was able to put in words some of the things that he found attractive. Other people also might see things in what you were practising that were, on some level, for their own reasons, extremely attractive. Sometimes it takes an outsider. There's this curious Melbourne Jewish practice of inviting converts on Shavuot to tell us why Judaism is really nice. There's almost need for someone who chose to be Jewish to remind us why we should appreciate it. Maybe sometimes it takes an outsider to put across those ideas.

Mason: To reinforce it, for sure.

Interviewer: I'm fascinated by your mum. She sounds like an absolute dynamo. You speak about her as being this absolute powerhouse. In what way? I mean, she put you guys through a Jewish day-school, she sent you away on March of the Living and, yes, she sent you off on a gap year. Economic commitment alone is already substantial. But beyond that, what was it that, this many years later, you're looking back and going, "She was critical."

Archer: Mum's - she's not academically brilliant or a raging career woman. **She's just very strong**. She was a black sheep in her family always, like she travelled to South America in the '60s alone, or '70s alone - unheard of. Married a non-Jewish man, which people weren't doing in those days from Holocaust families. And her dad went to the grave, our grandfather went to the grave, not accepting my father, and she did it anyway. And so her strength of Jewish identity because of my grandparents is huge, even though she went to a non-Jewish school - she was at Balwyn High and never went to a Jewish school. But Judaism was so important to her and so she built that into the fabric of our lives in everything she could. Again, her Jewish literacy is not nearly as like ours. She is Habo, which is huge - that lineage is there.

And she's a teacher as well, so she dedicated raising us as - the ultimate education is raising a child, I think, raising a human being. So she dedicated that and **we were her project**. So from the fact that we all had to pick an instrument aged six, and we learned with the Suzuki method, which meant the parent practised with the child every day. It meant an hour and a half/two hours of music just through the three of us, it's just that level of dedication. So that was it. It was just her **complete and utter presence and dedication to us and our growth as a family**, I think, and tireless. I'm a parent now and I look back through that lens at her and it **blows my mind her level of dedication to us**.

Interviewer: I think you guys have given her a pretty good report card for those efforts.

Archer: Definitely A plus, plus, plus as a mother.

Mason: Ashton, did you have anything to say on that? I'd love to hear what you have to say in terms of mum's influence.

Ashton: No you.

Mason: Huh?

Ashton: I'd like to hear what you have to say.

Mason: Nah, too late. I flagged you first, mate.

Ashton: I think Archer, you said it very beautifully and summed it up. So what I think is just **that incredible presence** and just **always there for all of** us in terms of attention and caringness and support and education. As the third child I probably had more - I had **multiple role models to look up to**. I had four - two for Archer, three for Mason and I had four, so I guess, in a way, I was lucky to have everyone and I think **our mum's love and education filtered also through Mason and Archer as well to me**. I was probably the luckiest to receive that love and attention filtering through the whole family, so maybe a different experience to you Archer being the first child, but I think Archer said it beautifully.

Commented [User9]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme prioritises the specific metaphors and labels created by the participants to define their self-concept.

Archer describes the siblings as their mother's **"project"**, a metaphor illustrating the intensity of their primary socialization.

Commented [User10]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
This theme identifies the mesosystemic laboratory by showing how macro-level factors (school, youth movements) are filtered through micro-level family dynamics.

Ashton explicitly maps the **relational filtering** of his identity, noting that as the youngest, his mother's "love and education **filtered** also through Mason and Archer as well to me".

Mason: [Laughs] I can't say anything - exactly the same. Exactly the same. I think I only realise now how - I still don't understand like, when I left to move to Israel, how did mum support? If I had a kid and my kid was saying to me, "I'm moving across the world and I plan on living there," which is what I said when I moved. I said, "I'm living there. I'm leaving Australia. I'm not coming back." And there was not a hesitation of her questioning that. She was like, "What are you going to do?" And I still remember that image. I came back once or twice and I was in a bit of a painful state, I started to miss family in the beginning, but also very connected and wanted to live there, and mum was probably in a pain cave. She was like, "Of course I want to have my son back." And she wouldn't waver. She was like, "Where do you need to be?" and "What do you need to do?" and always made me feel whatever I did - like I'm a Jewish boy but I'm farming.

My career does not bring in a lot of money. It's a risky business to be in. It's away from the Jewish community and she makes me feel like the most special person for what I chose, still. So it just empowered us to do whatever we wanted. So even doing crazy stuff like, "Hey, we're going to start a secular Jewish community and say this is a legit way of expressing our identity." Like she did. She brought us up in kind of like, I don't know, traditional ortho. She was like, "A hundred percent. Do that. If that's what make you guys feel is where you express, let's go the whole way. I'll be the first person to be at your Shabbat service." That's epic.

Archer: Yeah, I think I remember saying at our wedding, in my wedding speech, it was like, "A lot of parents, they say to their kids, 'Dream' and then there's a 'but'. There was no 'but for mum. There was never a 'but'."

Interviewer: BUT go and do Arts/Law at Monash.

Mason: Exactly.

Archer: BUT have a backup. **There was no 'but' in our life. It was just 'dream'. That's it. Full stop. I got your back**.

Mason: Yeah. She's a legend…

Archer: Are there any clear take-homes or learnings or standouts or red thread or anything at all, so far?

Interviewer: Something that comes to me is that people seem to be more at peace with something that they continue to grapple with. You guys invented something. It didn't exist here. A congregation, a way of being Jewish. That's a very powerful idea.

Archer: Yeah.

Mason: Just to reflect. **Those who have lived with some sort of intentionality around their identity or their boundaries or practices or those with more intentionality are at more peace genuinely**. Yeah? I'm just fascinated.

Interviewer: It's an initial thought. If you create something, already you're intentional, already you're thinking about it. But already you might have been dissatisfied with something, or at least not fully satisfied, and in that tinkering process that's already fundamentally meaningful. Not everyone gets to where you guys have gotten to in terms of that thinking process at this stage of your lives. It's a privilege to behold. Thank you so much for your time.

Archer: Thank you.

Commented [User11]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses sibling dialogue to distinguish between "identity optimization" (refining stable commitments) and fundamental developmental crises.

The interviewer reflects this theme back to the siblings, noting that their creation of the **Jewish Humanist community** is a sign of "intentionality" rather than disengagement—an active "tinkering process" that resolves the "Searching Moratorium paradox" through concrete communal building.

Mason: Thank you.

Archer: Good luck.

Ashton: Thanks for the opportunity to chat. It was really lovely.

Archer: Yeah, a privilege for us.

Interviewer: And an absolute wonderful opportunity.

END OF TRANSCRIPT